



ABSENS ATOMUS

Paper I

The Verdict Needs a Judge

On whether absolute absence can be called impossible, malformed, or silent

A defense of one premise, written to be attacked.

What this paper is for

This is not the whole theory. It defends one sentence and leaves everything else alone. I had a longer framework with a lot of moving parts, but when I showed it around, everyone who looked at it went after the same joint, without comparing notes. So rather than defend the whole machine, I want to pull out that one joint and see if it holds on its own. If it doesn't, none of the rest matters, and I'd rather know.

The sentence is roughly this. You can't dismiss absolute absence. Not by calling it impossible, not by calling it malformed, not by calling it silence. Because all three of those are verdicts, and a verdict needs something outside the thing it's judging to do the judging. Absolute absence has no outside. So there's nowhere for the verdict to come from.

That's it. That's the whole paper. The rest is just me trying to make that sentence earn its keep, and pointing at the place I think it's weakest.

The setup

Start with a definition. Absolute absence is the lack of every property. No matter, no energy, no space or time, no cause, no information, no logic, no observers. And the part that actually does the work later: it also lacks the property of being the absence of all properties. There's nothing left in it to point at, including its own absence.

I'm not going to pretend I can prove this state ever obtained, or even could. I only want to ask whether it's coherent, and what happens when someone tries to say it isn't.

There's a familiar worry that a state defined this hard turns on itself. To be absence it has to be the case in some way, but being the case is already a property, and it was supposed to have none. And if it isn't the case, then something else is sitting where it should be. So it can't quite manage to be, and it can't quite manage not to be. People notice this and usually treat it as a reason to throw the whole concept out. The throwing-out is what I want to look at, not the worry itself.

Three ways people throw it out

As far as I can tell there are three. They sound different but I think they're closer than they look.

Impossible

The first one says a contradiction is just impossible, and impossible things don't happen, so nothing comes of it. This is the one most people reach for first. It treats impossibility as a kind of final ruling that closes the file.

Malformed

The second says the definition is so overloaded that it stops referring to anything. Like the phrase the largest prime number, which looks like it names something but doesn't. If the description never picked out a real state, then there's no state there to be contradictory, and nothing to resolve. The concept was bad from the start.

This one is sharper than the first, I think, because it doesn't even grant that there's a contradiction. It says there was never anything coherent enough to contradict.

Silence

The third is the quiet one. It doesn't say impossible and it doesn't say malformed. It just says the right outcome is nothing. No existence, but no problem either. Nothing got asserted, so nothing follows. I find this the hardest of the three to argue against, because it barely asserts anything to grab onto.

What the three have in common

Here's the thing I keep coming back to. Each of these does something, and it's the same kind of something every time. It passes a judgment on the contradiction.

Calling a thing impossible is evaluating it and ruling it out. Calling a description malformed is holding it up against some standard of what counts as well-formed and failing it. Calling the result silence is surveying the situation and announcing that nothing's licensed. None of those is just noticing something neutral about the world. Each is a verdict, and the verdict gets delivered onto the contradiction from somewhere.

And a verdict isn't a free-floating thing. Somebody, or something, hands it down. To rule a thing out you have to be standing somewhere to rule from, and that place is outside the thing you're ruling on. I don't think that's a controversial claim about ordinary cases. It's just usually invisible.

Take the largest prime number again. When we say that's incoherent, it's the rules of arithmetic doing the work, and arithmetic is standing outside the phrase, looking in. When we say some contradiction is false, there's a logic outside it that catches it and sends it to false. The evaluator is always there. We don't usually notice it because we never have a reason to ask where it's standing. The ground is solid, so we don't check it.

Why absence is the case where you have to check

Absolute absence is the one place the ground isn't solid, because there isn't any. By its own definition it has no logic in it, no standard, no system, no position anywhere apart from itself. So when someone says it's impossible, I want to ask, impossible according to what? There's no arithmetic in there to call it malformed. No logic in there to call it impossible. No vantage point from which silence is the correct reading, because a vantage point is a thing, and there are no things.

So the conclusion I land on, and I'll admit I'm not fully sure of it, is that the three dismissals aren't actually describing what absolute absence does on its own. They're describing what someone standing outside it would conclude. But there's no one standing outside it. Remove that someone and the dismissal can't even be spoken. Not because it came out false. Because there's no longer any place to speak it from.

Every way out of the contradiction is a door of some kind, and a door opens onto an outside. This thing doesn't have an outside. I don't think it has a door.

The objection I can't settle

Now the real problem, and it's the reason this is a paper and not a victory lap.

The obvious response is that my own argument turns on me. If there's no evaluator around to call the contradiction impossible, then there's no evaluator around to call it real either, or generative, or whatever positive thing a larger theory would want to say about it. The missing outside should gag the theory just as much as it gags the critic. Fair. That's a good objection and I don't want to wave it off.

Here's the best I've got, and you can tell me if it's real or just a relabel. All three dismissals are trying to get the contradiction to settle. Into impossible, into incoherent, into silent. And each of those is a resting place, a state where the matter is closed. Settling is an outcome, and an outcome is the thing that needs a judge to certify it. But the other claim, the one that says

with no judge nothing settles, isn't itself a verdict. It's not announcing a result. It's just observing that no result can be reached, because there's nothing that could reach one. Not-settling isn't pronounced from outside. It's what's left over when nothing can pronounce anything at all.

So if there's an asymmetry, and I think there might be, it sits at exactly one spot. The person dismissing the contradiction needs the outside to be present, so the case can be closed. The other view needs the outside to be absent, so the case can't close. And the line it just sits there quietly as nothing turns out to be sneaking the settling back in, because sitting quietly as nothing is itself a closed case, and closing the case is the move I think I've shown isn't on the table.

I genuinely don't know if that reply does work or if I've just given the problem a new coat of paint. That's the part I'd want a reader to push on before anything else.

A word about the way I'm talking

In the bigger framework I tend to say the contradiction turns inward, or folds, and people reasonably hear something active in that, as if there were some little will in there doing the folding. I want to be clear that nothing in this paper leans on that. The claim here is entirely negative. I'm not saying absence does anything. I'm saying it can't be made to settle, because every way of settling it needs an evaluator that isn't there. A thing that can't settle isn't thereby busy doing something. It's just not finished. The active-sounding words belong to the other papers and they can defend themselves there. This argument doesn't need them.

What would actually beat this

Since the point of writing it this way is to make it breakable, let me say plainly what a win for the other side looks like. You'd have to show me a dismissal of the contradiction that isn't a verdict. Some way of making absolute absence come out impossible, or incoherent, or nothing, that needs

no evaluating position anywhere at all. You'd have to show that impossibility can be intrinsic, that a thing can be ruled out with no standard doing the ruling, no logic, no vantage point in or out of the situation.

I can't find a way to do that, because every sense of ruled out I can think of involves a ruling, and every ruling seems to involve someone or something somewhere to do it. But I've been wrong about things that felt this solid before, and the burden is at least clear now, which is more than I could say a few drafts ago.

Where that leaves it

The whole thing comes down to one question. Can a contradiction be dismissed without a dismitter. I've argued it can't. Impossible, malformed, silent, none of those are things a contradiction is on its own. They're rulings handed to it from outside, and absolute absence has no outside to hand them from. So it can't be ruled impossible, can't be ruled malformed, can't be ruled silent. It can't be dismissed, because there's no one anywhere to do the dismissing.

And a thing that can't be dismissed and can't settle doesn't quietly disappear. It stays, unfinished, with no way out. What follows from it staying is the business of the later papers. This one is only trying to show that the staying can't be argued away, and that the easiest-looking ways of arguing it away all quietly borrow the one thing absence doesn't have.



End of Paper I.